start developing a serious psychological problem about not chasing well against India – we would go into the final, and India would go home: out of the World Cup but still with a win against Pakistan hanging from their belts.

Then, a mirage was constructed. We cruised to the semis after shrugging off Zimbabwe – Saeed bhai got his first century in the tournament, Wajahat also finally clicked and Saqlain got a hat-trick to close the deal at The Oval. Batting at number seven, I was the third-highest scorer (37 off 29, 1x4, 2x6), finally understanding how to tackle a seaming English wicket. Playing me down the order at that position was working, although I wasn't comfortable batting in the slog overs. Those days, I still fancied myself as an opener.

But during the semi-final, against New Zealand, the day belonged to Saeed bhai and Wajahat – they made the biggest World Cup opening partnership of 194 – and Saeed bhai scored his second century in a row. Shoaib Akhtar, the Rawalpindi Express, who had already bowled the fastest ball of the tournament at 95 mph against South Africa, broke a Kiwi stump in each of his bowling spells in that match. We would win by nine wickets with 15 balls to spare. Despite all the doubts cast on the integrity of the side after our loss to Bangladesh, it felt like we were peaking at the right time.

I barely got any sleep the night before the final. Unlike the last time in a championship final involving the Aussies, there was no 'night out' either. There were a lot of young players with an unbelievable sense of pride in the team: Abdul Razzaq, Saqlain, Shoaib and I. Wasim bhai was leading us from the front. Never has a team like that been put together by Pakistan. It was a solid unit.

But in the aftermath of the Bangladesh match, there was doubt and controversy brewing. Personally, in a warm-up session before the final, I twisted my ankle while playing football. I was super stressed and up all night, icing the sprain, and eventually had to get a couple of injections to reduce the pain so that I could play the final. I wasn't in top form, but would still be the third highest scorer at 13 – which doesn't say much about the team, nor me.

As for the final – which was a disaster, with us all out for 132 in just 39 overs – we made the fatal mistake of batting first, especially given that the conditions were overcast and, as everyone knows, the ball moves around a lot in England on such mornings. Also, there was the Shane Warne factor to deal with as well. Warne – who scooped a record 20 wickets in the tournament – owned us that day. Our runs on the board didn't look defendable in any case. So, towards the end, our tail-enders just went after everything they could. The chase for the Aussies was easy and they wrapped up proceedings four and a half hours before time.

That match went down as the shortest final in World Cup history. It marked the beginning of the rise and rise of the Australians as the most ferocious ODI side in the world, and they would remain at the top for the next decade and a half. Of course, we were dejected by the outcome of the final – we have yet to make it to another World Cup final since that day – but there wasn't a lot of soul-searching in the Pakistan dressing room after the defeat. Wasim bhai told us all to chin up: we had made it to the final after a helluva run and had lost only to the finest, the Aussies. And that was that.